Lesson 8 Develop one question in 45 minutes

Write and submit in the final 45 minutes of the class. The final report is the sole basis of grading; classroom participation and learning behaviour are not graded.

Scope

Choose one case discussed in class, or a specific subject of your own. Write either a research proposal or a case review in about four paragraphs. New experiments, measurements or literature searches are not required.

Paragraph	Content
1	Define one question, subject, region and period.
2	Explain which tree-ring evidence and methods address it.
3	Discuss one alternative explanation and evidence for comparison.
4	State the limits of the conclusion and what to check next.

A practical guide is about 250–400 English words. This is not a minimum or a grading criterion. A shorter report can meet the criteria if its evidence and reasoning are sufficient. Use a short title that states your question in the task field of the supplied paper.

Course materials and notes are allowed; internet access is unnecessary. A reference such as “Lesson 5, slide 7” is sufficient to identify a course source. There is no required number of references or figures. Distinguish proposed work from completed measurements.

Suggested time allocation

Five minutes to choose a question and evidence; 30 minutes to write; ten minutes to check reasoning, alternatives, limits and identification details. Timing choices are not graded.

Lesson 8 A short example and the rubric

This fictional building and its dates illustrate reasoning. This is not a required answer to copy; build your own question and evidence.

1. I ask how far timber can constrain a building date. In this fictional practice case, the last surviving ring of a beam is assigned to 1750, while a documentary record concerns 1758. Neither bark nor sapwood survives. Are the ring date and construction date interchangeable?

2. I would first inspect support for the 1750 assignment: the securely dated reference, overlap, matching features and investigation of mismatches. The exercise provides no crossdating record, so 1750 is a stated assumption, not a result I have independently established.

3. Lesson 5 explains why loss of the outer wood matters. The last surviving ring does not alone fix the felling year; later rings may have been removed. Even if the document concerns construction, it may not apply to this beam. Later repair or reuse of older timber are alternative explanations.

4. Neither felling nor original construction is established by these facts alone. I would examine the original document and the part of the building it describes, joints and working traces, and other timbers retaining their outer edges. Comparing their dates could help distinguish a single construction episode from repair or reuse. Source for the principle: Lesson 5, slides 5–8. The building and dates are fictional practice assumptions.

Criterion (20 points each)	Where it appears in the example
Question and scope	1: subject and distinction between dates
Evidence and methods	2: what must support the crossdate
Comparison and logic	3: loss of wood, repair, reuse and documentary context
Evidence and referencing	3–4: source location and separation of fictional assumptions
Conclusion, limits and next steps	4: limits and specific additional evidence

Total: 100 points. Use 20, 15, 10 or 5 as attainment guides for each criterion; no relevant statement receives 0. Length or format alone does not determine a full score; judge the reasoning and evidence actually presented.